

Centering the Woman's Experience: A Strength of Maggie Little's Analysis on Abortion

Benham Cobb

The ethics of abortion have traditionally focused on the fetus to determine moral permissibility. Maggie Little, however, relocates the ethical discussion from the 'thin' question of the permissibility of abortion to "thick" questions of its morality concerning intimate and relational dimensions. Specifically, she centers the lived, embodied experience of pregnant women in order to answer such questions. This article argues that this focus is a strength of Little's analysis. It first describes how she wields the woman's experience to characterize the abortion discussion in a richer sense beyond abstract judgments of permissibility and to expose the absence of intimacy, relationship, and process that limits traditional accounts to a narrow ethics of destruction. By an "ethics of destruction," this article refers to frameworks that evaluate abortion solely in terms of whether it wrongfully kills the fetus, abstracted from the lived reality of gestation. Little, by contrast, explores these neglected dimensions and articulates a balancing ethics of creation, which weighs the moral significance of ending fetal life alongside the moral responsibilities and identity commitments involved in bringing a child into the world and sustaining that life after birth. The discussion then develops her notion of respect for responsibility to argue that her account, which is grounded in an ethics of care attentive to relational and contextual moral judgment, accommodates the full range of lived experiences in ways that polarized, principle-driven abortion debates cannot. Finally, it challenges Little's notion of motherhood through the case of Merritt Tierce and engages Patrick Lee and Robert George's communitarian account as a critique, while arguing that centering the woman's experience ultimately promotes an ethics of care capable of withstanding that objection.

Right to Life, Personhood, Future-like-ours: Neglecting the Woman's Experience

Ethical literature has struggled to establish the moral permissibility of abortion. Thomson's thought experiments, notably the unconscious violinist analogy, defend abortion under the assumption of the fetus's right to life. Warren, however, claims that Thomson's right-to-life assumption is too strict to establish moral permissibility and, instead, concludes that fetuses have no right to life based on an absence of personhood. In a similar vein, Marquis claims that personhood theories cannot straightforwardly account for the wrongness of killing and, instead, concludes that abortion is *prima facie* seriously morally wrong, as with killing any human being, since fetuses share identical futures as us. These disagreements persist, particularly through objections concerning whether fetuses possess interests, whether equality between persons requires equal moral consideration, and whether psychological connectedness grounds the wrongness of killing.

While Little acknowledges the imperative to establish moral permissibility (i.e., answer the "thin" question), she instead focuses on capturing the types of moral promise to which no attention has been given (i.e., answering the "thick" questions). This new inquiry does not create a separate arena of abortion that adds to our moral understanding, but rather provides a more accurate conception of abortion that attunes our moral understanding to the nature of gestation. Because gestation is an embodied and relational process that shapes both the pregnant woman and the developing child, moral analysis must attend to how pregnancy is lived and experienced rather than treating it as a morally neutral background condition.

For example, consider Warren's and Marquis' arguments: while they capture opposing views of the abortion debate, they both neglect the woman's

experience and revolve around a moral framework centered on killing. In Warren's piece, neither the fetus's resemblance to a person nor its potential for personhood provides any basis whatsoever for a right to life, and it is therefore morally permissible to kill the fetus in the same way that it is permissible to kill an entity lacking personhood. In Marquis's piece, abortion is presumably morally impermissible, as it falls in the same moral category as killing an innocent adult human being. We can attribute this shared focus to an ethics of destruction, in which abortion is evaluated solely in terms of whether it wrongfully kills or harms the fetus, without regard to the relational and identity-forming dimensions of gestation. Moreover, we can attribute these arguments to ethics of justice, where morality is centered on abstract principles and rules that can be applied to everyone. Because the woman's circumstances do not meaningfully affect either verdict of moral permissibility, these arguments aim to produce a universally applicable moral rule for all women—an abstraction that obscures the moral relevance of pregnancy as lived and experienced.

Yet, an ethics of destruction—operating within an ethics of justice that prioritizes impartial rules—cannot fully describe the moral complexity of abortion. Because not ending a pregnancy is tantamount to creating a person who has needs, a balancing ethics of creation on the social and emotional state of the mother and growing child after birth is equally important. For the woman, keeping the pregnancy entails a commitment to motherhood that now brings her identity to bear on the decision to abort. Understanding this identity shift requires examining how Little conceives of motherhood and responsibility. Warren's and Marquis's arguments fail to capture the change in the woman's identity from this commitment to motherhood and are, thereby, inadequate to assess the moral complexity of abortion. Therefore, an ethics of creation that centers the woman is necessary to cultivate a joint relationship between her and the fetus.

Now consider Thomson's analogy of the unconscious violinist, where unplugging oneself from the violinist is the same as aborting the fetus. In "A Defense of Abortion," Judith Jarvis Thomson distinguishes between the demanding moral ideal of a 'Good Samaritan' and the more limited obligation of a 'Minimally Decent Samaritan,' arguing that while morality may praise extraordinary sacrifice, it typically requires only minimal decency toward others. She uses this distinction to suggest that pregnancy does not automatically obligate a woman to sustain the fetus

at significant cost to herself. However, the maternal nature of pregnancy transforms those responsibilities from stranger-to-stranger to what parents owe to their children—where parenthood exists as a social role, a relationship, an intertwinement, a motivation to sacrifice. Due to these complex and subjective layers, ethics of justice cannot exactly pinpoint the responsibilities a woman ought to have. By contrast, ethics of care centers morality on interpersonal relationships and contextual information. Little argues that, in the intimacy of the mother's pregnancy, only the woman is capable of seeing the true nature of the circumstances following her pregnancy. In other words, only the mother is capable of foreseeing what her child deserves as it enters the world.

Because pregnancy involves layered relationships, evolving responsibilities, and subjective moral meanings, Little argues that an ethics of care—rather than abstract principles—is better suited to guide moral judgment. Centering the woman's lived experience allows this care-based approach to inform an ethics of creation that responds to the realities of gestation. In this way, Little shifts the abortion debate from a fixed moral category of killing to a moral understanding of creation that is generalizable in its recognition of gestation's transformative significance, yet relationally defined rather than dictated by abstract universals.

Respect for Responsibility: Finding a Middle Ground

This section considers the weighty responsibility involved in creating human life to clarify the subject-sensitive and relational scope of Little's framework across all lived experiences. This respect for responsibility concerns how pregnant women understand and respond to the moral weight of creating human life, whether that responsibility is expressed through continuing or terminating an unsought pregnancy. For the former, the child-bearer may feel an amplified responsibility to nurture by bringing about the fetus's existence; it is indecent to create life without enabling it to reach its end state. However, Warren argues for trivial reasons that "whether or not it would be indecent (whatever that means)...to obtain an abortion...it ought to be permitted." The notion of decency, then, is an element of Little's framework that Warren effectively dismisses. Because pregnant women occupy diverse identities, commitments, and moral frameworks, Little's account treats moral judgment as responsive to each woman's considered understanding of decency and responsibility rather

than fixed by universal criteria. Although Warren's framework permits the continuation of pregnancy, her dismissal of decency as morally relevant reflects its reliance on abstract and universally applied standards rather than relational moral evaluation.

This responsibility may also be steered in the opposite direction on the scale of decency. The woman may feel it indecent for her to bring a child into the world, e.g., for a life of injustice and hardship. Yet, Marquis claims under his future-like-ours account that abortion could be justified only if the consequent value of failing to abort is at least as great as the value of losing the future. The child's life would not be worse than non-existence, so it would be seriously immoral to abort the fetus. Because Little's framework shifts focus onto the woman, continuing the pregnancy under circumstances she uniquely understands may conflict with her own considered ideals about responsible creation and parenthood—systems that are neither universal nor objective, but contingent on the woman's situation. The woman certainly believes that the fetus would have a future, but she may decide to abort the fetus to maintain her integrity. Therefore, the respect for responsibility involved in creating human life exemplifies the full range of women's experiences captured by Little's framework.

Motherhood and the Case of Merritt Tierce: Ethics of Care in Practice

To be a mother is to be committed to meeting demands of preservation, growth, and social acceptability. Because gestation initiates a morally significant maternal relationship without necessarily producing a settled maternal identity, responses to pregnancy fall along a spectrum: some women affirm that relationship by welcoming the child, while others terminate in order to avoid assuming an identity and set of obligations they do not embrace. The final section presents the case of Merritt Tierce as suggesting a weakness of centering the woman's experience, but argues that an ethics of care grounded in this focus withstands the objection. Of particular interest are the following components of the spectrum: submission to morally authoritative institutions (e.g., of Christianity) to continue pregnancy, and adherence to virtues that orient one's practical identity (e.g., of receptivity to life's agenda to terminate pregnancy). Women may have conflicting moral systems within this ethics of creation in deciding whether to continue or terminate the pregnancy—a situation in which indecisiveness results in continuing the pregnancy.

In her essay, "The Abortion I Didn't Have," Tierce

reflects on her experience of contemplating an abortion that she eventually did not have. At the moment of the realization that she was pregnant, she faced a mandatory, urgent decision-making process, where she felt she "couldn't consider abortion or adoption" but "also couldn't consider having a baby." Within Little's framework of responsibility and maternal identity, Tierce was a Christian who believed that abortion was immoral, and had valuable plans of studying at Yale Divinity School in believing she wasn't ready to be a mother, among other influences (e.g., punishment from premarital sex to continue pregnancy, guilt from being the child's mother to terminate pregnancy). Tierce had the baby but, in the process, lost her autonomy, stunted her relationship with parents, left her religion, and felt disharmony with being a mother.

Tierce's ambivalence may appear to expose a vulnerability in Little's emphasis on lived experience: pregnancy does not always generate a coherent or embraced maternal identity. Tierce was pregnant yet resisted identifying as a mother, and this unresolved intimacy—neither detached nor fully embraced—is not clearly theorized within Little's framework. Her case suggests that when indecision results in continuing a pregnancy, the woman may face profound hardship upon entering the maternal role. From this perspective, one might argue that abortion ethics should provide determinate guidance when a woman feels incapable of deciding for herself, thereby decentering her experience. A communitarian account of motherhood, such as that offered by Patrick Lee and Robert P. George, situates mother and child within a broader moral community whose shared norms may override individual uncertainty. On that view, community standards could legitimately supply the decision that the woman herself cannot reach.

Although this communitarian objection raises an important challenge to Little's framework, it ultimately reinforces the importance of her care-centered approach. The ethics of care as established in Little's framework involve caring responsiveness from the physician to the woman, knowing how to respond well with relevant virtues of care. While the period of uncertainty as exemplified by Tierce may arise, centering the woman entails the practical element of dealing with such indecisiveness in clinical care. In Sara Ruddick's feminist account of maternal care ethics, she found that "loving attention helps mothers to perceive their children and themselves honestly so as to foster growth without retreating to fantasy or incurring loss of the self."

While Ruddick's care ethics focuses on the

developmental stage, it demonstrates the sort of introspection with which pregnant individuals can engage and grow authentically. Tierce's piece reveals a loss of identity throughout the process of child-bearing, whereas Little's care-centered framework would support the woman in sustained moral reflection on her relationships, commitments, and capacities so that she can navigate uncertainty without relinquishing her agency or sense of self. In this way, she would discover and maintain what she values in motherhood and in her individuality by determining what is best for her child and not necessarily the community. Therefore, centering the woman's experience strengthens Little's ethics of creation under ethics of care.

Conclusion

Debates over abortion often remain fixed on the thin question of permissibility, asking whether abortion constitutes the wrongful killing of a fetus. By centering the lived, embodied experience of pregnancy, Maggie Little redirects attention to thicker moral questions concerning intimacy, responsibility, and identity. This shift exposes the limits of principle-driven accounts that reduce the moral landscape to an ethics of destruction and instead articulates an ethics of creation attentive to the relational and transformative dimensions of gestation. While communitarian accounts of motherhood challenge whether such a framework risks moral fragmentation, an ethics of care grounded in the pregnant woman's situated experience proves capable of sustaining moral seriousness without collapsing into relativism. Recognizing pregnancy as a morally complex process rather than a mere biological condition reframes abortion not as a detached act of killing, but as a decision embedded within ongoing networks of care, responsibility, and becoming. In doing so, Little's account offers a more comprehensive and humane framework for evaluating the moral dimensions of abortion.

References

- Gilligan, Carol. "Moral Orientation and Moral Development." In *Women and Moral Theory*, edited by Eva Feder Kittay and Diana T. Meyers, 19–33. Totowa, NJ: Rowman & Littlefield, 1987.
- Hopper, Kipp. "On Maternal Obligation: The Lens of Motherhood in the Abortion Debate." Quinnipiac University School of Health Sciences, 2017.
- Lee, Patrick, and Robert P. George. "The Wrong of Abortion." In *Contemporary Debates in Applied Ethics*, edited by Andrew I. Cohen and Christopher Heath Wellman, 37–50. Malden, MA: Blackwell, 2005.
- Little, Margaret Olivia. "The Moral Permissibility of Abortion." In *Contemporary Debates in Applied Ethics*, edited by Andrew I. Cohen and Christopher Heath Wellman, 51–62. Malden, MA: Blackwell, 2005.
- — —. "The Morality of Abortion." In *Ethical Issues in Modern Medicine*, 6th ed., edited by Bonnie Steinbock, John D. Arras, and Alex John London, 492–499. Boston: McGraw-Hill, 2003.
- Marquis, Don. "Why Abortion Is Immoral." *Journal of Philosophy* 86, no. 4 (1989): 183–202.
- McInerney, Peter K. "Does a Fetus Already Have a Future-Like-Ours?" *Journal of Philosophy* 87, no. 5 (1990): 264–268.
- Pedroni, Julia. "What Does Pain Medicine Want from a Feminist Ethics?" In *Pain Medicine: Philosophy, Ethics, and Policy*, edited by James Giordano and Mark V. Boswell, 95–106. Linton Atlantic, 2009.
- Ruddick, Sara. *Maternal Thinking: Toward a Politics of Peace*. Boston: Beacon Press, 1995.
- Sander-Staudt, Maureen. "Care Ethics." *Internet Encyclopedia of Philosophy*. <https://iep.utm.edu/care-ethics/>.
- Thomson, Judith Jarvis. "A Defense of Abortion." *Philosophy & Public Affairs* 1, no. 1 (1971): 47–66.
- Tierce, Merritt. "The Abortion I Didn't Have." *New York Times Magazine*, December 2, 2021.
- Warren, Mary Anne. "On the Moral and Legal Status of Abortion." In *Classic Works in Medical Ethics*, edited by Gregory Pence, 169–182. Boston: McGraw-Hill, 1998.